classed as underprivileged. And the Madhesi (the Terai or plains-origin people) who constitute about 28 per cent and live in districts bordering India. The constant power tussle within these groups has made the country's polity less cohesive.

What made the student rebellion significant was that it struck hard at Kathmandu, considered the bastion of the powerful Pahadi communities. The choice of targets reveals a deeper rupture, with demonstrators attacking not just institutions of democracy like Parliament and Supreme Court but also the homes of party leaders across the political spectrum. Interestingly, protesters stormed the Nakkhu jail in Lalitpur and freed Rastriya Swatantra Party president and former deputy prime minister Rabi Lamichhane. A popular TV anchor who had championed transparency and spotless governance, Lamichhane was implicated in a cooperative fraud scandal dating back to 2019 and had been sent to judicial custody in April 2025. Maj. Gen. Basnyat highlights how members of the Gen Z, raised in an era of global connectivity, economic uncertainty and political stagnation, had lost faith in the system. "Their mobilisation," he says, "reflects a rejection of an exhausted political order that has failed to deliver stability, justice or opportunities. Instead, they are pressing for a deeper recalibration of governance and security, where corruption, impunity and outdated institutions are replaced by accountable leadership and forward-looking strategies."

ROYALIST SPECTRE

When army chief Sigdel addressed the nation with a portrait of Prithvi Narayan Shah, the 18th-century founder of modern Nepal, behind him, the symbolism was unmistakable. Many wondered if royalist forces would return riding the new wave of anger. Royalist sentiment has been flickering for years, spiking visibly in November 2023 when thousands rallied in Kathmandu, including members of the right-wing Rastriya Prajatantra Party, for a revival of monarchy and a Hindu Rashtra, clashing with the police. The 78-year-old Gyanendra Shah, who ruled Nepal from 2001 to 2008, was overthrown after a popular protest that upended the monarchy. Currently living in the Nirmal Niwas Palace in Kathmandu, he continues to nurture hopes of a return to power. The current turmoil revives the spectre of a royal return. Dr Geeta Kochhar, senior assistant professor, Centre for Chinese and South East Asian Studies, JNU, believes, "Nepal's Gen Z has lost faith in the ruling Communist alliance. This could pave the way for a new political alignment involving the royalty."

Some see royalist interest in the collapse of the constitution that abolished the monarchy, but others point out how recent pro-monarchy crowds were a fraction of mainstream party mobilisations. "Individuals, yes; a force, no," says an expert. "The monarchy is over. Some may hanker for it, but the current revolt was not for that." The trend line points away from legacy loyalties and toward identity, accountability and delivery. It is tempting to reduce Nepal's turbulence to a royalist plot, a leftist gambit, a Chinese angle, or an Indian misstep. The reality is messier. "Everyone's giving some geopolitical angle... but this is a homegrown thing," insists an interlocutor.

There remains deep concern, though, that the new dispensation may try to alter the constitution on the pretext that it failed to deliver. Among the dilemmas is that, under the constitution, only a member of the lower house can serve as prime minister. Can an unelected PM head an interim government, then? As a Nepal expert warns, "If the constitution is jettisoned, it's all up in the air. There are dangers of opening old fault lines between various caste and social groups.

THOUGH THE OLD TRIUMVIRATE OF LEADERS ALTERNATED IN POWER TILL RECENTLY, THEIR PULL HAD WEAKENED AND THEY HAD DIMINISHING RESONANCE WITH THE YOUNG

KEY PLAYERS IN NEPAL

THOSE WHO WERE OUSTED, AND THOSE ON THE RISE



K.P. SHARMA OLI, 73

Four-time ex-PM (2015, 2018, 2021 and since July 2024) from the CPN (UML). Resigned on Sept. 9 as protests spiralled. Accumulated power, used probe agencies against rivals. Faces contempt case for blocking a court order against converting a tea estate into commercial plots. His residence was torched, currently in hiding.